dates the Hindu vote in Punjab, which is a sizeable 38 per cent.

The Hindus have traditionally voted for the Congress as they still remember the party's tough stand against militancy. The BJP realises that Amarinder comes with the baggage of anti-incumbency, but he could also help split the Congress. The strategy seems to be working as the Congress, fearing a further depletion, retained most of its MLAs for the contest, even if perceived to be non-performers. Amarinder has also helped the BJP get into Sikh institutions that have moderate Sikh preachers and build a rapport with them. Damdami Taksal chief Harnam Singh Dhumma, for instance, had issued a public statement praising the prime minister for declaring December 26 'Veer Baal Diwas' as a tribute to the martyrdom of Guru Gobind Singh's younger sons Zorawar Singh and Fateh Singh. Amarinder is believed to be very close to this seminary. With Dera Sacha Sauda chief Ram Rahim Singh out on a furlough, BJP leaders are using Amarinder's network to reach out to him for political support—that's a substantial number among the non-elite castes. BJP leaders and Amarinder believe that the elections will most likely throw up a hung house. They have two options: team up with SAD again to form a government or, if no favourable permutations are within reach, have President's rule imposed.

Khichdi is usually a winter dish in the north. But there are many who see a platterful of it coming in the spring of 2022—the sheer number of ingredients going into the Punjab potboiler seem to make that a likely outcome. The delicious irony is that each side thinks it has a chance. AAP, which has a perceptible quantum of street cred, is hoping this will be their breakout opportunity. The Congress under Channi thinks voters may give the state's first Dalit CM a second term. Sukhbir feels he deserves to be CM after having served as his father's deputy for years. If he falls short of numbers, he could build bridges with the BJP. Or, as a wildcard, even join hands with the Congress—presently a taboo thought for the panthic party. But as the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi has shown, anything is possible in politics. Will the War of the Sardars hold a twist in the tale? Like with most potboilers, everyone will still be guessing the climax right up to the forenoon of March 10. ■



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INTERVIEW

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